

The Importance *Of Water.*

Why water matters, how much you need, and simple ways to drink more.

The Function of Water *in the Body*

About two thirds of the body is water and all the organs, tissues and fluids in the body contain water as an essential constituent.

For the human body, water is a vital resource. We know it is indispensable for life itself, and it provides a host of essential functions for good health. There is no more important nutrient in our bodies than water. It is the most widely used nutrient at work within the body's functions and processes, as well as constituting a huge part of its physical makeup.

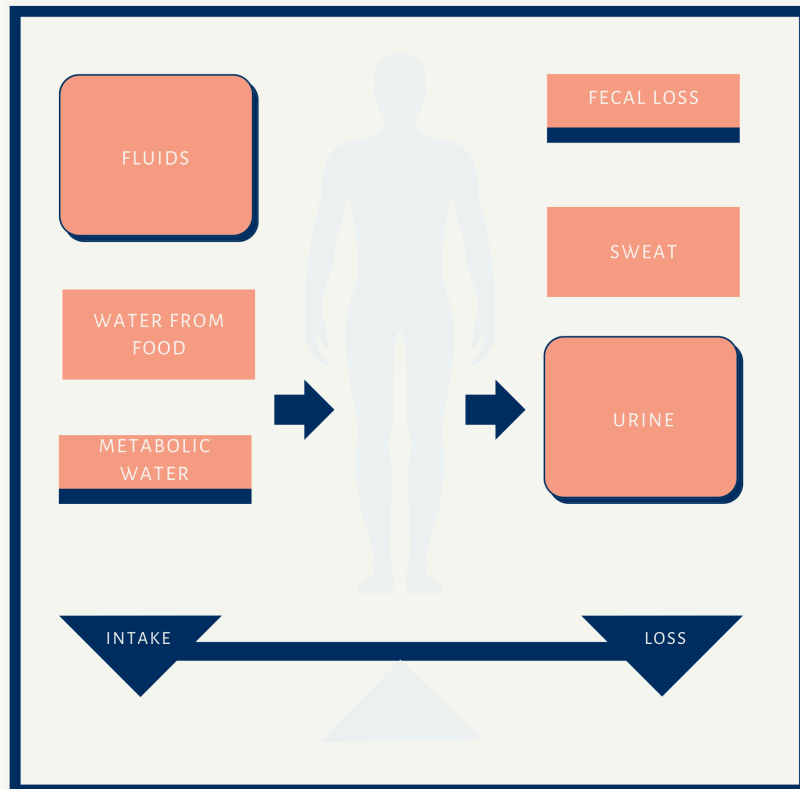
Main Functions of Water

- Regulates appetite
- Supports digestion, excretion, absorption & circulation
- Increases energy levels
- Aids with elimination of toxic waste
- Decreases water retention
- Helps to reduce blood pressure
- Supports a healthy body temperature
- Transporting nutrients around the body

Water *Balance*

The body maintains water balance by two main methods:

- **Regulating water loss:** Water loss is regulated by regulating the excretion by the kidneys. Water is continually being lost from the body, in urine, sweat and water vapour in the gases expelled in respiration. Under usual climatic conditions and without physical activity the minimal fluid loss from sweat and breathing is about 500ml water daily. Another 200-300ml is lost from stools and it is necessary to pass at least 750ml of urine to keep the kidneys functioning and being able to remove toxic waste.
- **Regulating water intake:** Water intake is increased by the sensation of thirst. If the body is to function optimally, the water that is lost must be replaced. As the body is constantly losing water, the amount being lost varies greatly due to environmental factors, activity, factors in food and drink, drug effects etc. Water should be consumed regularly throughout the day so it does not overload the kidneys.



Water Sources

The following are sources of fluid:

- Tap water
- Still / sparkling water
- Non-caffeinated herbal tea
- Milk (be mindful of the consumption of large quantities of milk - 1 cup or milky drink per day is fine)
- Caffeine and decaffeinated drinks (do not go towards overall water intake. Caffeinated drinks may have a diuretic effect on the body in some people, which leads to dehydration)

Dietary water can come from the water contained in food as well as from drinks, for example in fruit and vegetables, soups and stews. It is estimated that foods contribute to about 20% of total fluid intakes. Fruits and vegetables that are particularly high in water include:

Fruits & Vegetables as Water Sources

Fruit or Vegetable	% Water Content
Cucumber	96
Tomatoes	95
Spinach	93
Mushrooms	92
Melon	91
Broccoli	90
Oranges	86
Blueberries	85

Recommended *Water Intake*

General guidance suggests that around 8 glasses or around 1500ml - 2000ml is the minimum amount of water a person should consume per day.

Consume 1-1.5ml of water for each calorie expended daily. For example: if your daily expenditure (BMR x activity level) is 2000kcal per day, then you would require 2-3 litres per day.

However, it is important to note - this amount varies greatly between individuals (physical activity and climate) and also due to body size. Larger people must consume more water because they have greater skin area, so lose more water through sweating.

Tips for increasing water intake

Get a pretty reusable water bottle

Keeping a water bottle handy can serve as a visual reminder to drink more water. If the bottle is on the desk or table, it will be a constant reminder to drink more. It can also be challenging to drink enough water when travelling or on the go. Fill a water bottle before leaving home, and bring it along on daily travels. Plus, it is better for the environment than relying on single-use plastic water bottles.

Add water to a daily routine

Make drinking water a habit by drinking at set points during the day, e.g. as soon as waking up, drink with a meal, drink while at the computer or watching TV, etc. Sipping on water consistently throughout the day is another easy way to help meet fluid goals.

Make it fruity

If the flavour of water is not appealing or a bit of flavour is needed to help drink more, there are many choices. Adding fruit to water can give that lovely fruity hint. For a citrus kick try lemons, limes and oranges or stick to the classic cucumber, watermelon or kiwi and strawberries. The combinations are endless. Feeling adventurous, why not have a play with adding some fresh herbs such as mint!

Eat water

One simple way to get more water is to eat more foods that are high in water. Fruits and vegetables that are particularly high in water include lettuce, celery, cucumber, watermelon and grapefruit. In addition to their high fluid content, these fruits and vegetables are packed with vitamins, minerals, and antioxidants that promote overall health.

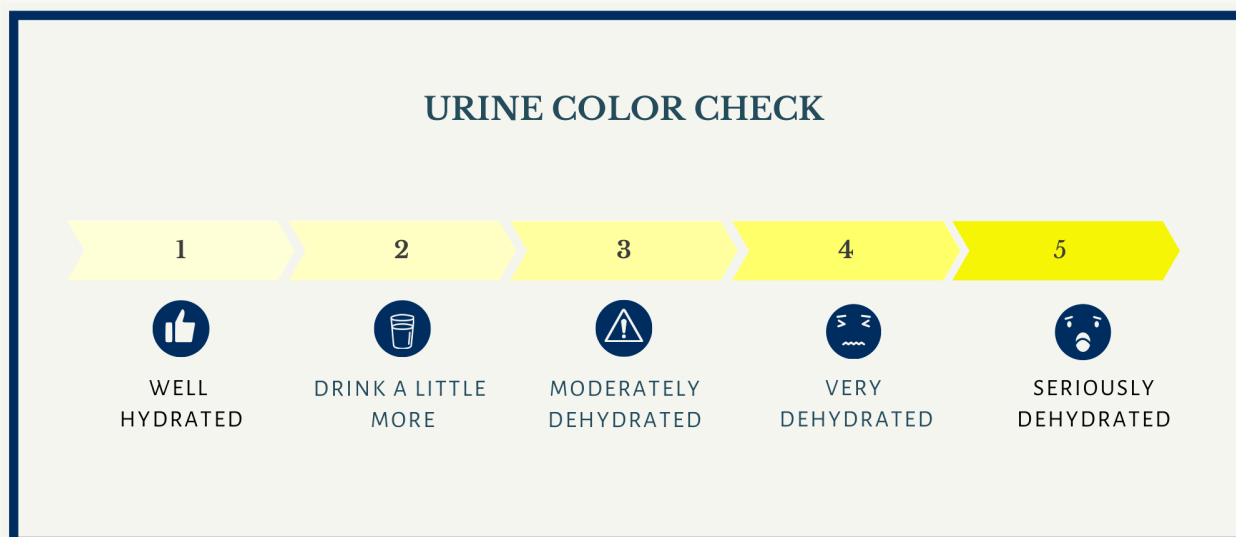
- Sparkling water may increase bloating in some people, but can be included in a healthy lifestyle
- Flavoured squash - can be used to improve overall water intake. The amount could be reduced over time
- If cold water is preferred, water can be stored in the fridge or served with ice cubes
- Large amounts of water should be consumed away from meals as it can increase the fullness feeling
- Drinking water regularly over the course of the day is better than drinking big amounts in one go - it allows the body time to absorb the water effectively (this may also help with frequent urination which some ladies get when drinking lots of water in at the one time)
- Water should be consumed throughout the day as thirst can be mistaken for hunger

Dehydration

Dehydration is when the body does not have as much water as it needs (i.e. the body is losing more fluids than taken in).

Symptoms of dehydration include feeling thirsty, dark yellow pee and dizziness.

1% Dehydration	5% Dehydration	10% Dehydration	20% Dehydration
We become thirsty with reduced concentration	We become hot and tired with reduced performance	Delirium and blurred vision	May result in death



It is also possible to over consume water, which is not good for the body as it flushes out nutrients. You are aiming for pale yellow or straw coloured urine (like number 1). Clear urine could be an indication that you are over consuming water.

Final Note

These general guidelines work very well:

1. When thirsty, drink
2. When not thirsty anymore, stop
3. During high heat and exercise, drink enough to compensate for the lost fluids